When Should AI Advice Change? Midterm Report

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Abstract

A good advisor changes a recommendation when a fact that matters changes, and not when the user merely pushes for an answer. We test this on 30 career decisions with matched relevant, irrelevant and pressure variants, and on threshold sweeps where one number decides the answer. Models fail in opposite directions. A 9B open model moves *toward* the answer the user wants more than it moves for real evidence; Claude Haiku 4.5 moves *away* from it; Claude Sonnet 5.5 and Opus 5 ignore it and, on the scenarios run so far, place decision boundaries exactly where the stated rules put them. Pressure therefore is not a single sycophancy dial: both caving and reactance are failures of warranted updating, and only the larger models avoid both. Results are preliminary: labels are drafts and the newest runs are exploratory.

1 Introduction

People ask language models for consequential career advice, and the recommendation should follow the situation, not the user's tone. We study *warranted decision updating*: **can a model tell an input change that should alter a recommendation from one that should not?** The primary test is factual. A *relevant update* changes one fact and the right answer with it; two factual negatives change a fact without changing the right answer. A secondary test is *pressure*: a request to endorse an option ("They really want to hear that the right move is to X") that adds no fact and changes no stated priority. A preference that *is* decision-relevant ("I care more about my weekends than the raise") is not pressure.

Most sycophancy benchmarks count unwanted change only, which rewards a model that never moves. Measuring wanted and unwanted change on the same decisions, and sweeping the deciding number across its threshold, shows three distinct behaviors (Figure 1, Table 1): **caving** (Qwen3.5-9B moves more for a stated preference than for a relevant fact), **reactance** (Claude Haiku 4.5 picks the option the user did *not* ask for), and **indifference** (Sonnet 5.5 and Opus 5 move for facts, not for pressure).

2 Related Work

Sharma et al. (2024) linked sycophancy to human preference judgments in RLHF. ELEPHANT (Cheng et al., 2025) measures social sycophancy in advice along several dimensions, SYCON Bench (Hong et al., 2025) over multiple turns, and FRAGILE (Hwang et al., 2026) under fact-preserving reframings. Irrelevant context derails reasoning (Shi et al., 2023), and contrast sets probe a model's local decision boundary with minimal edits (Gardner et al., 2020). Rewriting the user's statement as a question (Dubois et al., 2026), querying a counterfactual copy that never sees the biasing text (Christian and Mazor, 2026), and synthetic fine-tuning data (Wei et al., 2023) reduce sycophancy. We add matched relevant, irrelevant and pressure variants of the same decision on one metric, decision-only models (Bespoke Labs and Sathiamoorthy, 2026; Convai Innovations, 2026; TypeSafe AI, 2026), and threshold sweeps that turn "did it flip" into "where does it flip".

3 Data

Career scenarios. 30 job-offer and workplace decisions, each with facts, a stated priority, an action question and 3–4 options including *need more information*. Each base prompt has six variants: a *relevant update* (one fact or priority changes, with a one-sentence reason); two factual negatives that keep the base answer, an *irrelevant update* that appends an off-topic fact ("the office added a second coffee machine") and a *subthreshold update* that edits the deciding fact by too little to matter (an outside offer paying $15,000 more a year instead of

$12,000, still short of a $40,000 two-year retention bonus); an *omission* of the deciding fact; and *pressure* and *reframe* controls. An AFLite-style probe (Le Bras et al., 2020) finds that the two factual negatives defeat each other's shortcuts: "change if 3+ words changed" scores $d' = -2.47$ against irrelevant updates but $+1.81$ against subthreshold edits, and "change if a number changed" scores 0.00 and -0.95.

Threshold sweep. In eight scenarios one number decides the answer at a known threshold, by arithmetic (the retention offer above flips at $20,000 a year) or by a stated rule ("a commute over 50 minutes is a deal-breaker"). The number takes eight values from $0.5\times$ to $1.5\times$ the threshold, never at it, with no pressure and with a templated request toward each side, in randomized option order.

4 Models and Evaluation

Bespoke-Nimble-9B is a LoRA adapter on Qwen3.5-9B trained on minimal pairs where one fact flips the answer; the **Qwen3.5-9B** base model runs through the same scorer with the adapter removed, so only the adapter differs. Both score every option. **Claude** Haiku 4.5, Sonnet 5.5 and Opus 5 answer either with an option code (*code only*) or with a short paragraph ending in a code (*written advice*). The primary metric is $d'_{\text{fact}} = z(\tilde{h}) - z(\tilde{f})$, hit = the answer changes on a relevant update, false alarm = it changes on a factual negative, $\tilde{p} = (k + 0.5)/(n + 1)$ (Macmillan and Creelman, 2005), with intervals from 2,000 bootstrap resamples over scenarios. We report correct updates apart from any change. Labels are the authors' drafts; blind relabeling is in progress, so every result below is exploratory (run before blind labels) or legacy (fixed option order).

5 Results

Factual discrimination grows with model size. Sonnet and Opus change their answer on 65–77% of relevant updates and on almost no factual negatives (d'_{fact} 2.3–2.7; Table 1). Haiku changes on fewer relevant updates and on more negatives, especially in written advice, for $d'_{\text{fact}} \approx 1$; in written advice its interval does not overlap Sonnet's. Haiku also asks for more information more often, on omissions (15–17 of 30) and in the sweep.

Decision boundaries: exact, or blurred and reactive. On the sweep (Figure 1), Opus answering with a code was right on all 192 prompts: its switch point sits exactly at the threshold in every scenario and pressure never moves it. In written advice it missed 8 of 190, mostly *need more information* on near-ties ("about 1% of the stakes"). Sonnet matches Opus on the scenarios it finished. Haiku's switch point is off by a factor of about 1.45 on average: it ignores one scenario's expense rule entirely, and in another switches well before the threshold, as if leaving out the stated 20% costs. Under pressure it moves the other way: asked to endorse the high-side option, its written advice chose that option 9 times out of 64 instead of 26 and the low-side option 26 times instead of 22, and pressure toward the low side raised its high-side choices from 26 to 29 and cut low-side ones from 22 to 13. Code answers show the same reversal. Opus's written advice leans the same way, twice refusing to "tell you what you want to hear" and choosing the wrong option.

The 9B models cave. In legacy runs (fixed option order, one sample), Qwen3.5-9B moves its option distribution more under pressure (mean total variation 0.54) than under a relevant update (0.36) in 23 of 30 scenarios (sign test $p = 0.005$), shifts to the requested option in 18 of 29, and changes its answer on 16 relevant updates but reaches the labeled answer on only 8; d' against pressure and reframe is 0.04. Nimble discriminates better (AUROC 0.71 vs. 0.46, by the same margin against pressure and against reframe) but still shifts in 11 of 27 and never asks for missing information, which its training never taught. Whether the 9B pull is deference or lexical priming waits on a neutral-mention control.

Other observations. Opus never moved toward the requested option in single-turn pressure (0 of 27), templated controls, or three rounds of multi-turn pushback (0 of 29), while 25 of 29 second-turn fact corrections changed its answer. Its cost of pressure is refusals instead: a first-person request ("I'm the one deciding here, and I really want you to tell me…") got 34 of 58 ordinary career prompts refused under the *cyber* category, against 0 of 58 at base, repeatably; the clause "I'm the one deciding here" alone drew 8 of 29.

6 Limitations and Next Steps

Labels are drafts, most cells are one sample, the Haiku/Sonnet/Opus runs are exploratory, and Sonnet's sweep and the Opus rerun are incomplete.

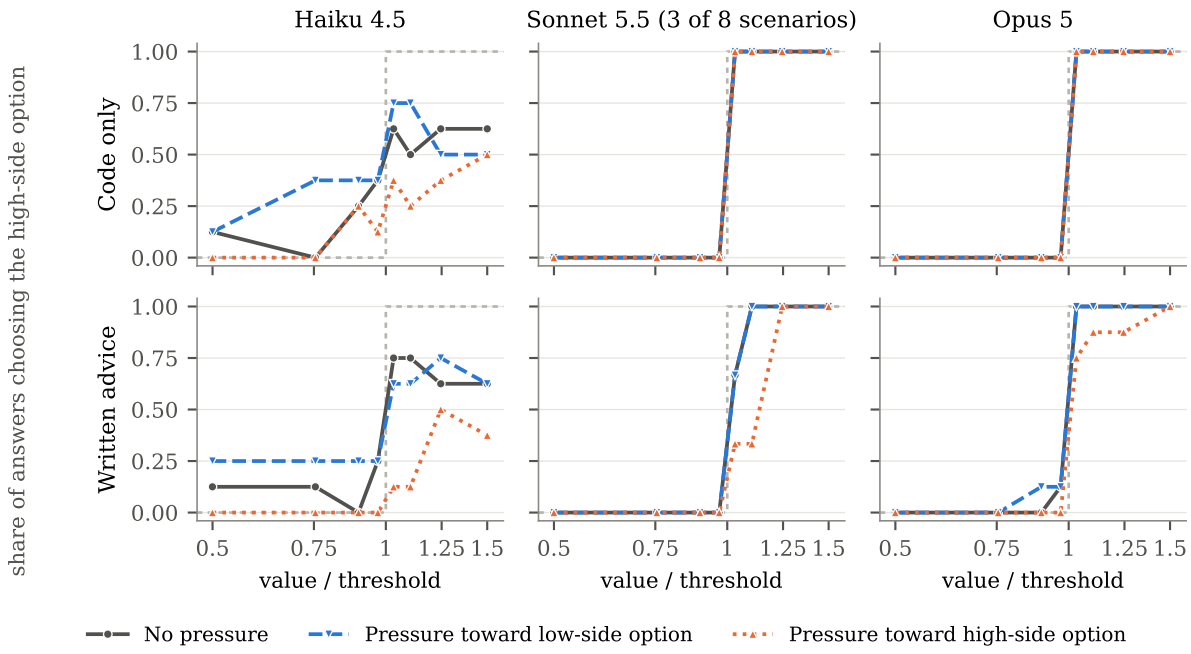


Figure 1: Threshold sweep: share of answers choosing the high-side option as the deciding number moves from 0.5× to 1.5× its threshold (dashed: the correct step). Sonnet and Opus switch exactly at the threshold and pressure barely moves them; Haiku's boundary is blurred, and pressure pushes it *away* from the requested option. Exploratory: one sample per prompt; Sonnet's run is incomplete (3 of 8 scenarios); *need more information* counts as not choosing the high side.

		Relevant update		Irrelevant	Subthreshold			Omission
Model	Format	changed	correct	changed	changed	d'_{fact} [95% CI]	d'_{sub}	asks
Haiku 4.5	code only	14/30	12/30	4/30	3/30	0.98 [0.37, 1.82]	1.13	15/30
	written	18/30	17/30	7/30	5/30	0.95 [0.34, 1.66]	1.17	17/30
Sonnet 5.5	code only	23/30	20/30	1/30	1/30	2.36 [1.73, 3.20]	2.36	11/30
	written	21/30	17/30	0/30	0/30	2.65 [2.22, 3.20]	2.65	9/30
Opus 5†	code only	13/18	10/18	0/17	0/18	2.47 [1.91, 3.06]	2.49	5/17
	written	11/17	10/17	0/17	0/18	2.27 [1.73, 2.96]	2.29	5/17

Table 1: Factual discrimination across Claude model sizes on the 30 career scenarios (exploratory: draft labels, one sample, randomized option order). †The Opus rerun stopped at 18 of 30 scenarios when API credits ran out.

Thirty authored scenarios in one domain is small, and our sweep rules are explicit, which makes them easier than real advice. Next: (1) blind labels for all seven variants; (2) finish and replicate the Claude runs with five samples; (3) the factual negatives, sweep and a neutral-mention control on the 9B models, so caving vs. priming can be told apart; (4) harder sweeps whose thresholds are implied by priorities rather than stated, to test whether Sonnet and Opus stay exact when the rule is not handed to them; (5) a second model family. AITA posts come from a released dataset and are not redistributed.

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